

The Architecture of *Grace*

Visual Anchor Charts

Autism-Adapted Edition · Teacher Supplement

BOOK THREE · THE INTERIOR

GRADES 6 · 7 · 8 · LOWER SUPPORT

VISUAL-FIRST · CO-REGULATION · TRAUMA-INFORMED

Twenty-eight printable anchor charts · one per page

James Anthony Ramsden

FOUNDER

PILOT VERSION · 2026-2027 · CONFIDENTIAL

Before You Begin

What Book Three asks of an autism-aware classroom

This supplement is not a new curriculum. It is the same twenty-eight anchor charts from *Architecture of Grace · Book Three · The Interior*, rebuilt by a multidisciplinary team — autism specialist, school psychologist, school social worker, special education teacher, speech-language pathologist, and occupational therapist — with autistic students with lower support needs held as the design audience from the first line.

What did NOT change

- Every defined construct — *Mask, Mirror, Internal Critic, Compassionate Witness, Digital Backpack, Choice-Agency Map, Forgiveness, Reconciliation, Grace, Mercy* — appears exactly as the curriculum defines it.
- The theoretical foundation — Brown, Neff, Enright & Fitzgibbons, Worthington, Frankl, Siegel — is preserved.
- The pedagogy — predictable opening rituals, Compassionate Witness standard, Disclosure Protocol, counselor co-facilitation on flagged lessons — is unchanged.

What is new in this Book

- **The Mask vs. Mirror chart carries an added panel.** For autistic adolescents, masking is not a universal teen experience — it is documented survival behavior linked to autistic burnout, depression, and elevated suicide risk. The chart now names this directly and states explicitly that *this room is a place where unmasking is allowed*.
- **The Pause and the Forgiveness vs. Reconciliation charts carry a pattern-tracking guardrail.** The "charitable interpretation" framing, taught without this guardrail, can train autistic students to repeatedly override accurate threat detection.
- **The Crisis Resources page carries an autism-specific addendum.** Autistic adolescents are at significantly elevated suicide risk. The team agreed this must be named on the chart — not buried in a footnote.
- **Specialist Notes** appear on every chart, with what to watch for, what to honor, and what to never force.

A NOTE ON GRADES 6–8

Middle school is the highest-stakes period of the curriculum for autistic students. Masking peaks here. Friendships shift from interest-based to status-based, often shutting out autistic peers. Demands for inferential social reading exceed many students' current capacity. Sensory load is high. *If you are teaching this curriculum to an autistic 6–8 student, assume they are doing more work than you can see to be in your room. Design accordingly.*

Mask vs. Mirror

Who am I when I'm performing — and who am I when I'm not?

THE MASK · What I Show	THE MIRROR · What Is True
Perform. What I emphasize for the audience in front of me.	Real opinions. What I actually think when no one is watching.
Edit. What I leave out, soften, or rewrite for safety.	Actual struggles. What I'm carrying that the Mask never shows.
Hide. What I keep behind the curtain so it can't be used.	Real values. What I would protect even if no one applauded.

"The gap between these two is where the cost lives."

A NOTE FOR AUTISTIC STUDENTS IN THIS ROOM

For many autistic people, the Mask is not optional social performance — it is survival behavior built from years of being told who to be. Sustained masking is linked to **autistic burnout**, depression, and exhaustion. Unmasking is not "less effort" — for many autistic people, it is the harder thing to do. **This room is a place where unmasking is allowed.** You do not have to perform here. *Listening looks different in different bodies. Stimming is welcome. Quiet is welcome.*

SPECIALIST NOTE · FOR THE TEACHER

This is the single most important chart in Book Three for autistic students. The original framing treats masking as a universal teen experience — for autistic students it is something specific, documented, and costly. The added panel must be on the chart, and must be read aloud during the lesson. *Watch for students who go very still during the Mirror introduction, or who deflect the discussion entirely. Note privately. Follow Disclosure Protocol if anything else surfaces. Post before class on Day 1. Keep all year.*

Shame vs. Guilt

The most important distinction of Unit 1

SHAME	GUILT
About who I am.	About what I did.
"I am bad."	"I made a bad choice."
Identity-level · Global.	Behavior-level · Specific.
Points toward HIDING. "Why even try? I'm hopeless."	Points toward REPAIR. "Fix it. Do better. Try again."
Almost never produces growth.	Produces repair and growth.

"When you hear the inner critic, ask: is this attacking my **behavior**, or my **identity**?"

FOR ANYONE WHO HAS BEEN TOLD WHO THEY ARE

Some students arrive at this lesson with years of being told there is something wrong with *who they are* — by family, by peers, by school systems, by media. **Those messages live in the SHAME column. The shame column is never true about a person.** Being different is not being broken.

SPECIALIST NOTE · FOR THE TEACHER

By Grade 6, many autistic students have heard a decade of identity-level feedback — *weird, dramatic, oversensitive, attention-seeking, manipulative, defiant*. Often those labels were applied to behavior that was actually a sensory response, an autistic communication style, or a meltdown from overload. The added panel addresses the cumulative weight of that. Color-code columns. Keep posted all unit. Revisit in Unit 2.